

Competing Risks and Multi-State Models

Concepts, methods and software

Course given at *Karolinska Institute*

May 5-8, 2026

Ronald Geskus¹ and Hein Putter²

¹ Oxford University Clinical Research Unit (OUCRU)

Hospital for Tropical Diseases, Ho Chi Minh City, Viet Nam

² Department of Biomedical Data Sciences

Leiden University Medical Center, Leiden, the Netherlands

Part II

Estimation: Multi-State Approach



Contents:

1. Cause-specific hazard
2. Aalen-Johansen estimator
3. Display formats
4. Censoring independent?
5. Cause-specific hazard:
standard Cox model

Outline

Aalen-Johansen Estimator

Confidence intervals

Display Formats

Marginal versus Cause-Specific

All quantities and their estimators

Assumptions on censoring and delayed entry

Independent right censoring?

What can we do?

Regression; proportional cause-specific hazards

Standard Cox model

Proportional cause-specific hazards

Exercises II

Probabilistic setup data

- Event time T_i ; may be right censored (administratively, loss to follow-up)
Censoring time C_i
 $X_i = \min\{T_i, C_i\}$, $\Delta_i = I(T_i \leq C_i)$
- Left truncation (late entry).
Entry time V_i
- Sample: $\{V_i, X_i, E_i \Delta_i\}, i = 1, \dots, N$
- Assume (V_i, C_i) independent of/non-informative for (T_i, E_i) (possibly conditional on covariables in regression model)

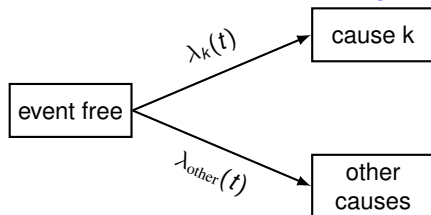
Observed data

$$\{(v_1, x_1, e_1 \delta_1), \dots, (v_N, x_N, e_N \delta_N)\}$$

Note: $t_i < c_j < v_{j'}$ in case of ties

- $x_i = \min\{t_i, c_i\}$, $\delta_i = \{t_i \leq c_i\}$, $e_i \in \{1, \dots, K\}$
- $t_{(i)}$ ordered unique event times of any type

Cause-specific hazard



- Individuals with a competing event are no longer at risk
⇒ leave the risk set

$$\widehat{\lambda}_k(t_{(i)}) = \frac{d_k(t_{(i)})}{r(t_{(i)})}$$

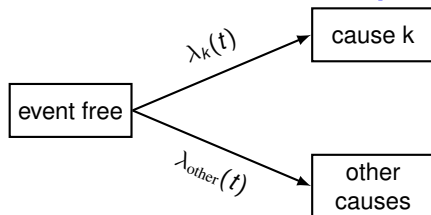
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- $t_{(i)}$ ordered unique event times of any type
- $d_k(t_{(i)})$ number of events at $t_{(i)}$ of type k
- $d(t_{(i)})$ total number of events at $t_{(i)}$
- $r(t_{(i)})$ number observed at risk

Cause-specific hazard



- Individuals with a competing event are no longer at risk
 $\implies$ leave the risk set

$$\widehat{\lambda}_k(t_{(i)}) = \frac{d_k(t_{(i)})}{r(t_{(i)})}$$

- Standard rate estimate:** same estimator as for marginal hazard (assuming independence), but different interpretation

Aalen-Johansen estimator of F_k

- Plug-in estimator based on $F_k(t) = \int_0^t \mathbb{P}\{T \geq s\} \lambda_k(s) ds$:

$$\widehat{F}_k^{\text{AJ}}(t) = \sum_{i: t_{(i)} \leq t} \widehat{F}^{\text{PL}}(t_{(i)}-) \times \widehat{\lambda}_k(t_{(i)}) \text{ with}$$

$$\widehat{\lambda}_k(t_{(i)}) = \frac{d_k(t_{(i)})}{r(t_{(i)})} \quad \text{cause specific hazard}$$

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$$\widehat{\bar{F}}^{\text{PL}}(t_{(i)}-) = \prod_{j: t_{(j)} < t_{(i)}} \left(1 - \frac{d(t_{(j)})}{r(t_{(j)})} \right) \text{ Kaplan-Meier}$$

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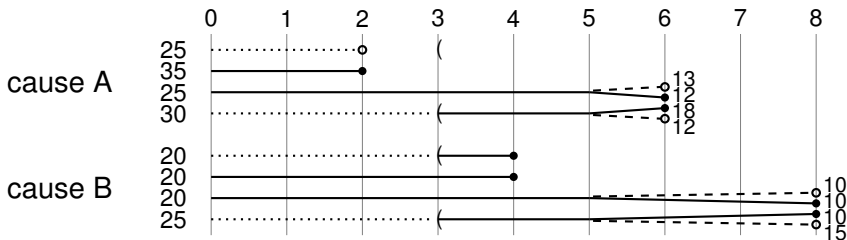
- Single event type: equal to Kaplan-Meier
- Competing risks: same hazard estimate as for marginal distribution, but cumulative quantity different

Example calculations

- 115 individuals die of A (60 at 2 years, 55 at 6 years)
- 85 individuals die of B (40 at 4 years, 45 at 8 years)

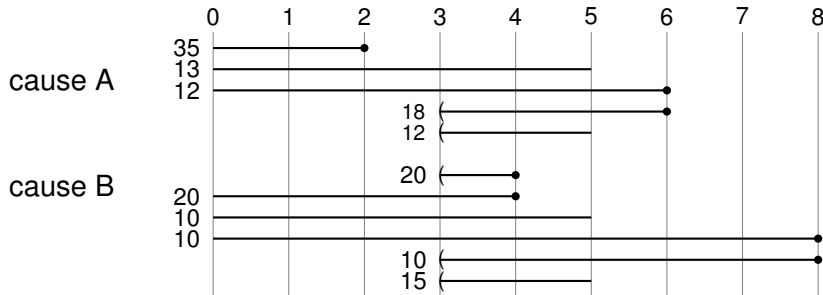
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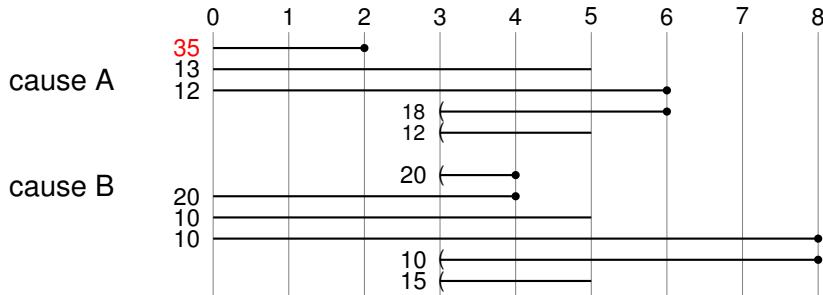
- 50 individuals censored after 5 years
- 100 individuals enter 3 years after the time origin (if they are still event free)

Detailed calculation of $\widehat{F}_A^{AJ}(2)$ and $\widehat{F}_A^{AJ}(6)$



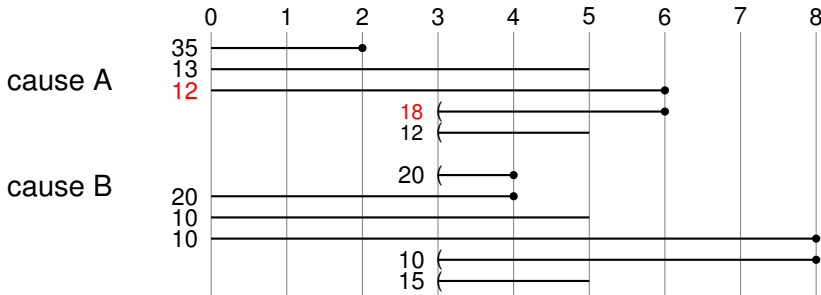
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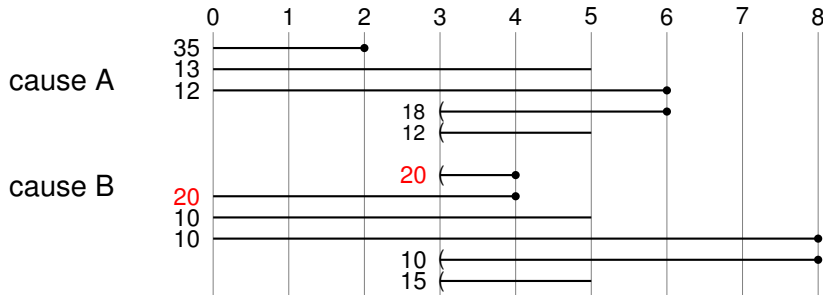
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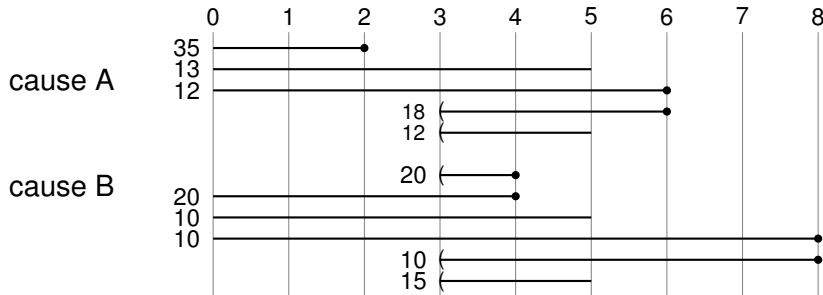
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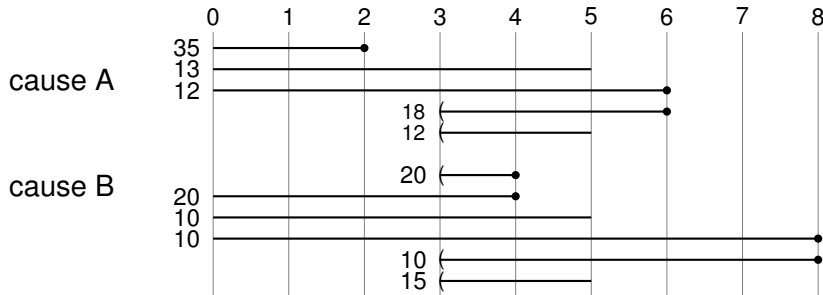
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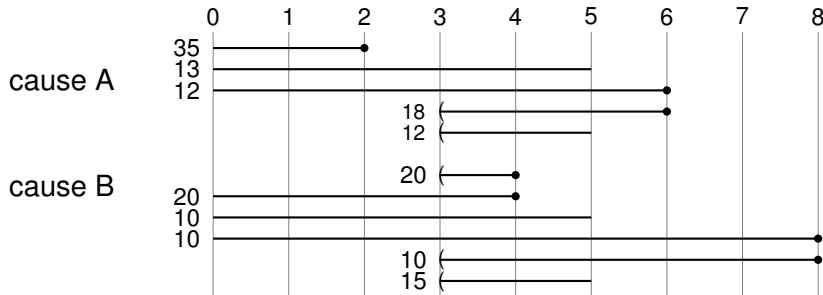
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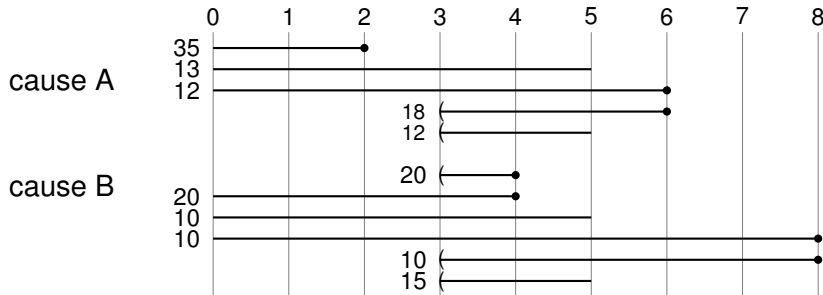
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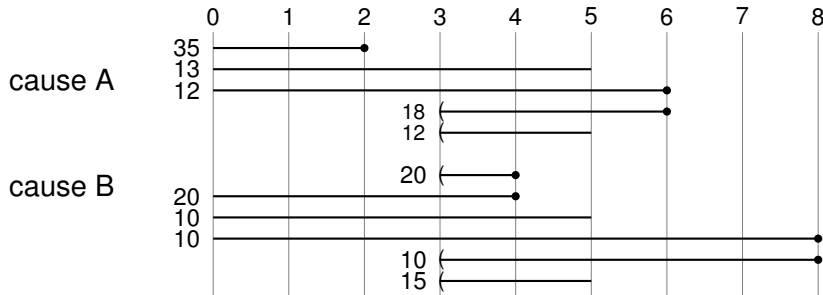
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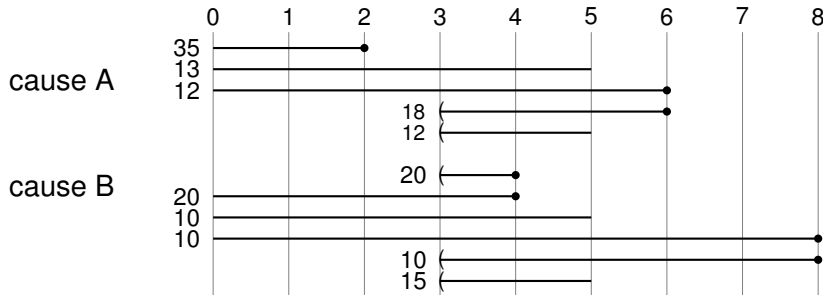
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Confidence intervals, Kaplan-Meier

Start with variance of Nelson-Aalen estimator $\hat{H}(t)$

$$\text{Aalen: } \widehat{\text{var}}\left\{\hat{H}(t)\right\} = \sum_{t_{(j)} \leq t} \frac{d(t_{(j)})}{r^2(t_{(j)})} \quad (1)$$

$$\text{Greenwood: } \widehat{\text{var}}\left\{\hat{H}(t)\right\} = \sum_{t_{(j)} \leq t} \frac{d(t_{(j)})}{r(t_{(j)})\{r(t_{(j)}) - d(t_{(j)})\}} \quad (2)$$

Use the delta method and $\hat{\bar{F}}(t) \approx \exp\{-\hat{H}(t)\}$ to obtain

$$\widehat{\text{var}}\left\{\hat{\bar{F}}(t)\right\} = \left\{\hat{\bar{F}}(t)\right\}^2 \times \widehat{\text{var}}\left\{\hat{H}(t)\right\}. \quad (3)$$

Confidence intervals, choice in scale

- On “plain” or “linear” scale:

$$\widehat{\widehat{F}}(t) \pm k_{\alpha} \widehat{\text{s.e.}} \left\{ \widehat{\widehat{F}}(t) \right\} = \widehat{\widehat{F}}(t) \pm k_{\alpha} \widehat{\widehat{F}}(t) \times \widehat{\text{s.e.}} \left\{ \widehat{H}(t) \right\}$$

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- On “log scale” [log survival; use $\log\{\widehat{\bar{F}}(t)\} \approx -\widehat{H}(t)$]:

$$\exp\left[-\widehat{H}(t) \pm k_{\alpha} \widehat{s.e.}\left\{\widehat{H}(t)\right\}\right] = \widehat{\bar{F}}(t) \times \exp\left\{\frac{\pm k_{\alpha} \widehat{s.e.}\left\{\widehat{\bar{F}}(t)\right\}}{\widehat{\bar{F}}(t)}\right\} \quad (4)$$

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- “log-log” or “complementary log-log” scale (use $\log \widehat{H}(t) \approx \log[-\log\{\widehat{F}(t)\}]$)

The “log” scale has best overall performance, but “log-log” scale best for small sample sizes (≈ 25 , $\leq 50\%$ censoring)

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Naming of scales inconsistent

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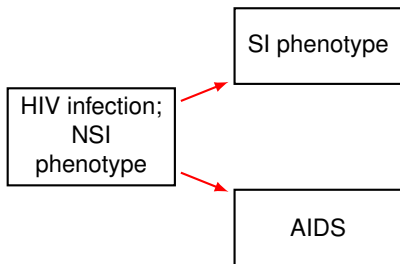
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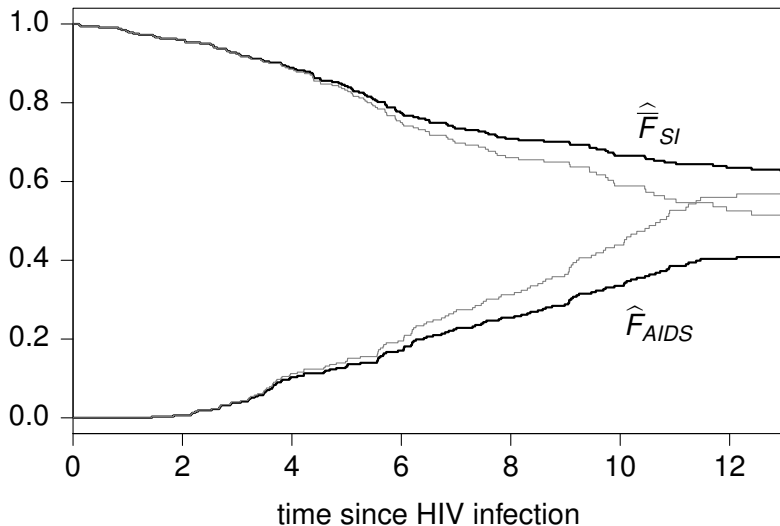
Exercises II

C: AIDS and SI switch after HIV infection

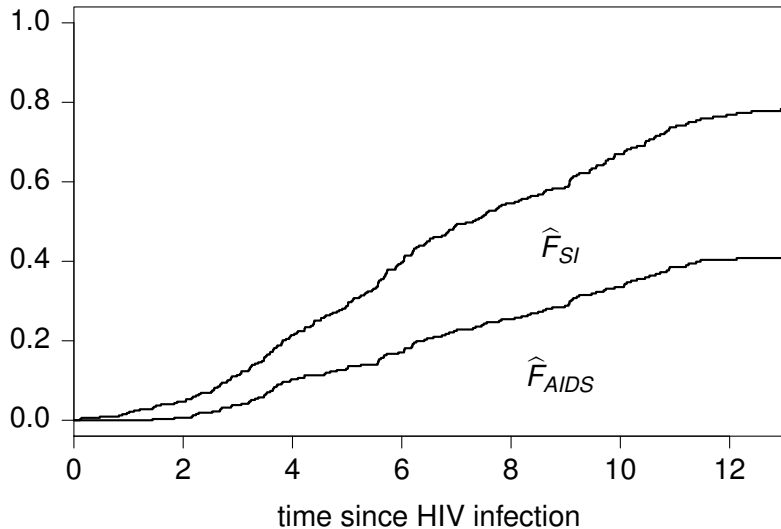


- SI: "syncytium inducing phenotype". At HIV infection only NSI
- Competing risks: time to either SI switch or AIDS **as first event**

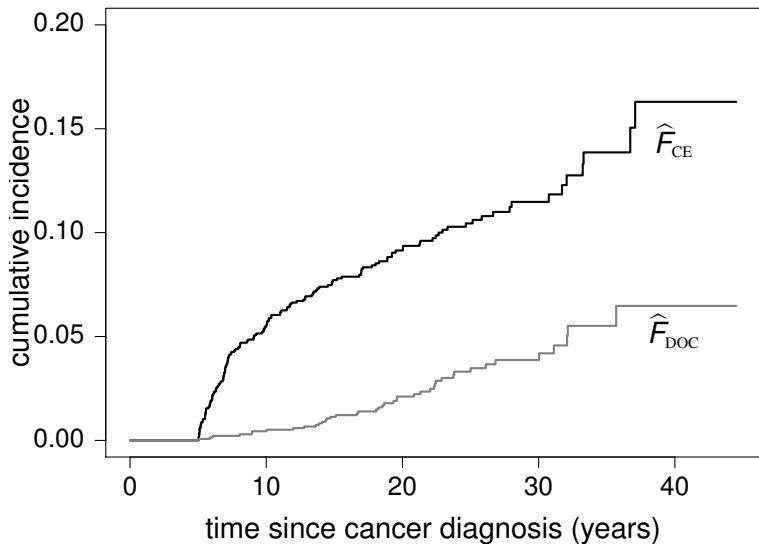
Alternate display format



Stacked display format

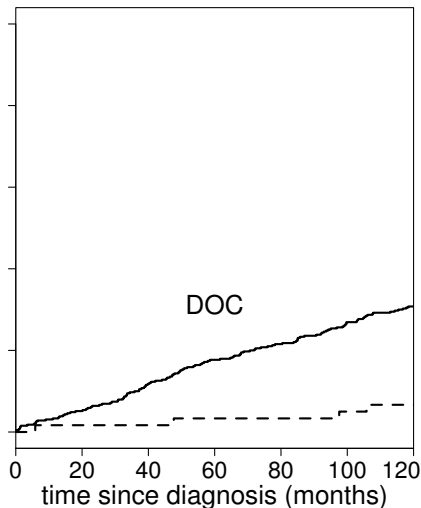
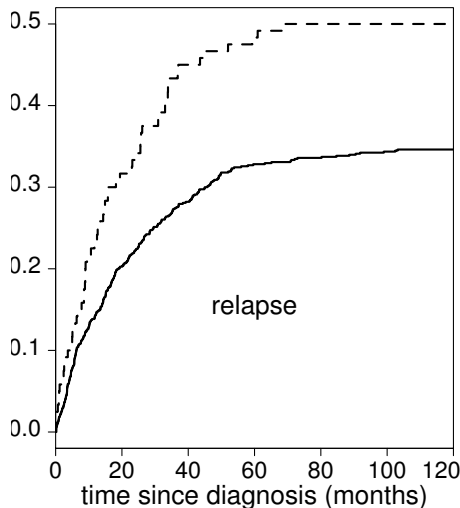


Overlaid display format (exercise II.10.2)



Childhood cancer survivors; cardiac event, DOC competing

Separate display format, two groups (exercise II.10.3)



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Independent right censoring?

What can we do?

Regression; proportional cause-specific hazards

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Rates and risks in competing risks setting

	hazard		cumulative	
competing risks	marginal	λ^m	net risk	$F_k^m(t)$
			marginal survival function	
			marginal cumulative incidence	
	cause-specific	λ_k	no corresponding quantity	
	subdistribution	h_k	crude risk	$F_k(t)$
			cause-specific cumulative incidence	
combined	overall	h	overall risk	$F(t)$
			overall survival function	
			overall cumulative incidence	

Estimators in competing risks setting

hazard	estimate	cumulative
marginal	$d_k(t)/r(t) = \widehat{\lambda}_k(t)$	$\widehat{F}_k^{\text{PL}} = \prod_{t_{(j)} \leq t} \left\{ 1 - \widehat{\lambda}_k(t_{(j)}) \right\}$
cause-specific	$\widehat{\lambda}_k(t) = d_k(t)/r(t)$	$\widehat{F}_k^{\text{AJ}}(t) = \sum_{t_{(j)} \leq t} \widehat{F}^{\text{PL}}(t_{(j)} -) \widehat{\lambda}_k(t_{(j)})$
subdistribution	$\widehat{h}_k(t) = d_k(t)/r^*(t)$	$\widehat{F}_k^{\text{PL}}(t) = \prod_{t_{(j)} \leq t} \left\{ 1 - \widehat{h}_k(t_{(j)}) \right\}$
overall	$\widehat{h}(t) = d(t)/r(t)$	$\widehat{F}^{\text{PL}}(t) = \prod_{t_{(j)} \leq t} \left\{ 1 - \widehat{h}(t_{(j)}) \right\}$

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Marginal distribution

- Estimated via (marginal) hazard, basis for Kaplan-Meier estimate of cumulative incidence/net risk
- Assumption: censoring (including from competing risk) is independent; censoring should give no information on residual time-to-event. Then censored individuals can be represented by the ones that remain at risk

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- Otherwise Kaplan-Meier has no interpretation. Does not describe survival in (hypothetical) world with competing event removed
- Extra information may allow to show dependent censoring (Example H-2, IDU and pre-AIDS death), but **independence** can never be tested for

Estimators in competing risks setting

hazard	estimate	cumulative
marginal	$d_k(t)/r(t) = \widehat{\lambda}_k(t)$	$\widehat{F}_k^{\text{PL}} = \prod_{t_{(j)} \leq t} \left\{ 1 - \widehat{\lambda}_k(t_{(j)}) \right\}$
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Competing risks

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Other censoring (administrative/loss to follow-up) must be independent

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 - Basis for Aalen-Johansen estimator of cause-specific cumulative incidence/crude risk
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Estimators in competing risks setting

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Assumptions for data analysis

- Competing risks: administrative right censoring and loss to follow-up non-informative
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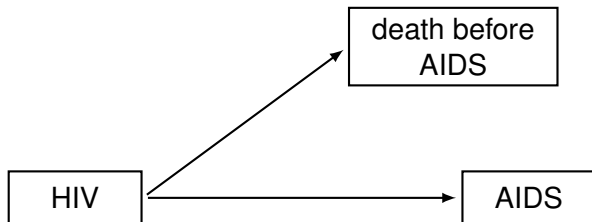
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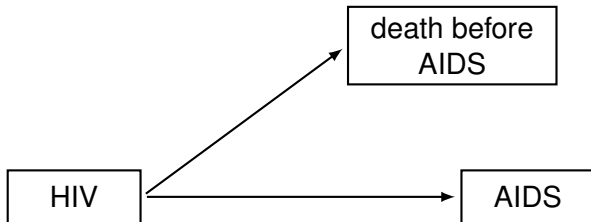
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Time from HIV infection to AIDS



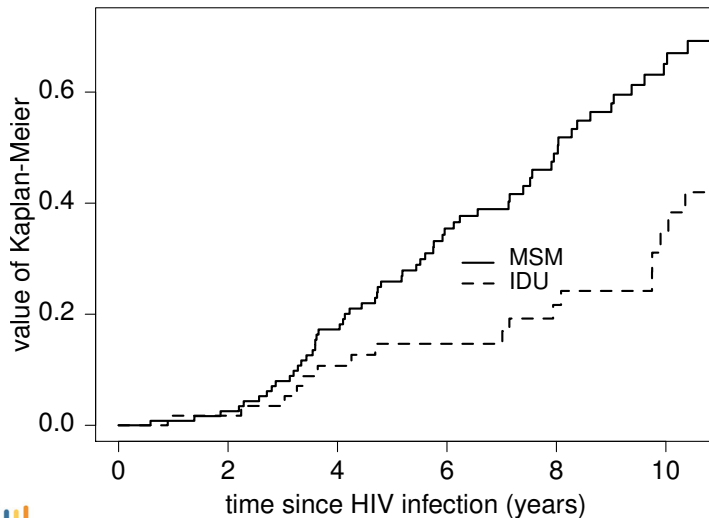
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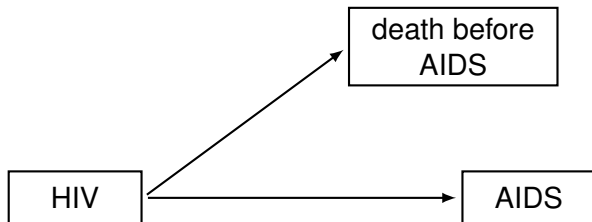


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- Interest in time to AIDS if there were no pre-AIDS death.
Interest in etiology and marginal distribution

Kaplan-Meier: IDU much slower progression ($p = 0.001$)



Time from HIV infection to AIDS



- Compare risk groups MSM and IDU
- IDUs expected to have faster progression to AIDS
- Interest in time to AIDS if there were no pre-AIDS death.
Interest in etiology and marginal distribution
- Kaplan-Meier: those who die before AIDS leave the risk set
Assumption: can be represented by those that do not die
- Can we test for independence?

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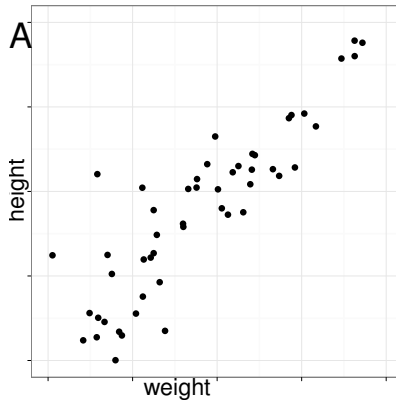
Regression; proportional cause-specific hazards

Standard Cox model

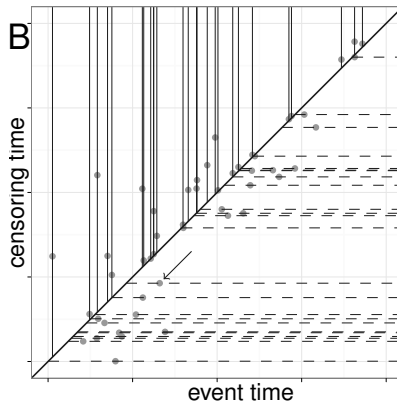
Proportional cause-specific hazards

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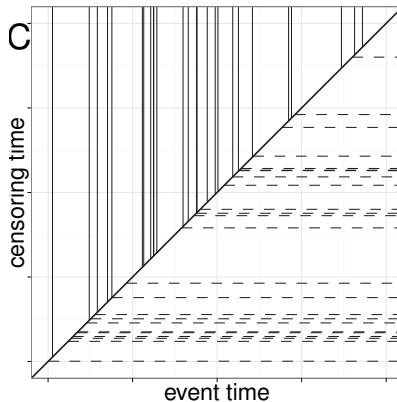
Cannot test for non-informative censoring



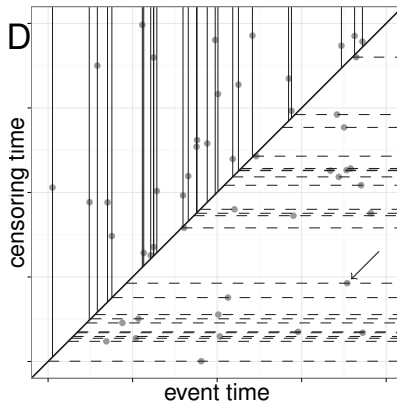
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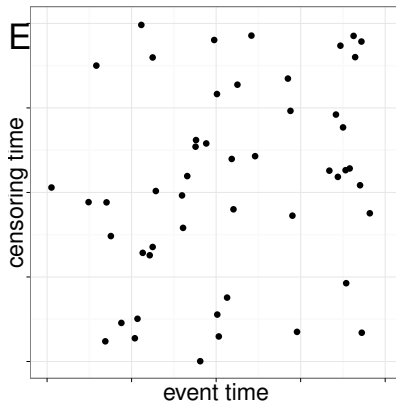
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Conclusion

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Reasons for right censored data

Cutoff date of analysis (administrative censoring) Censoring
usually non-informative

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Loss to follow-up May be problematic

- Sicker individuals discontinue participation in study (lack of energy, too ill, return to home country)
- Healthier individuals discontinue participation (don't feel the need to continue, start new life in other country)

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Competing risks Often there is some background mechanism that influences progression to the different end points, which makes censoring informative. In competing risks analysis, independence is not required.

Conclusion

- Same data can represent independent as well as dependent censoring
 - We cannot test for independence based on observed event/censoring data
 - No correction for dependence possible based on observed event/censoring data
- Extra information may allow to show dependence, but independence can never be tested for

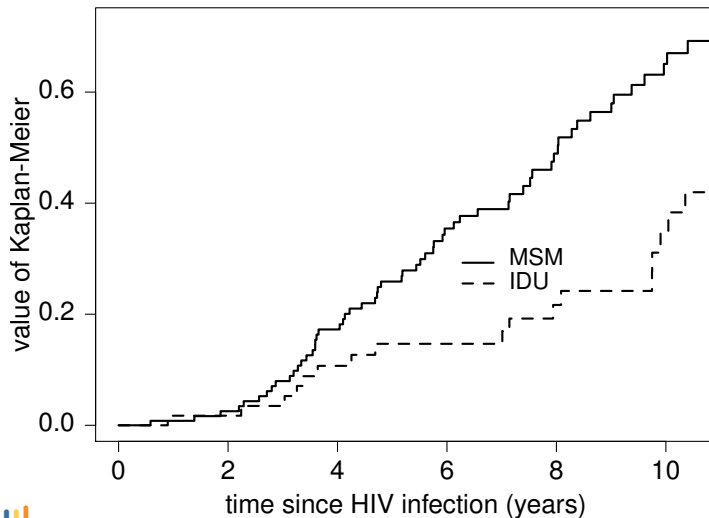
Explanation difference between IDU and MSM

- Extra information on cause of death before AIDS

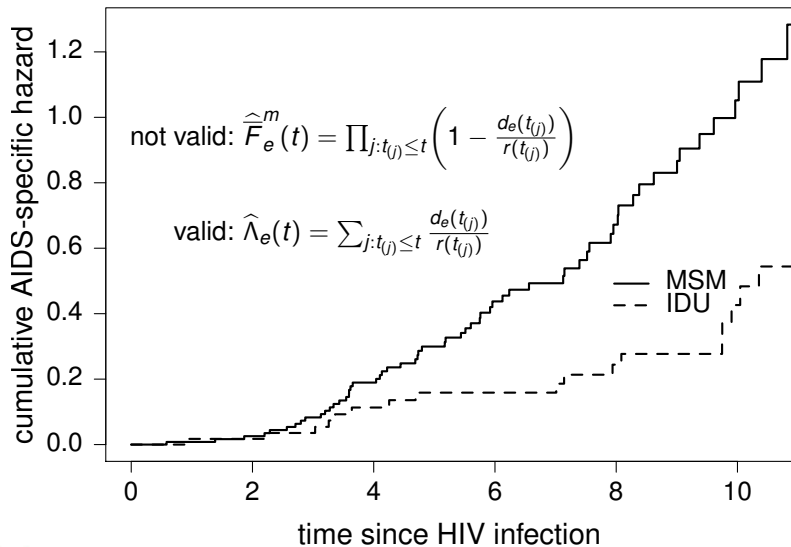
	IDU	MSM
Reason of death	Number	
HIV related infections	3	0
overdose/suicide	6	0
violence/accident	2	0
liver cirrhosis	2	0
cancer	0	1
heart attack	0	1
unknown	4	3

- Some pre-AIDS death causes in IDU related to AIDS progression. Censoring close to AIDS, hence net risk for IDU biased downwards

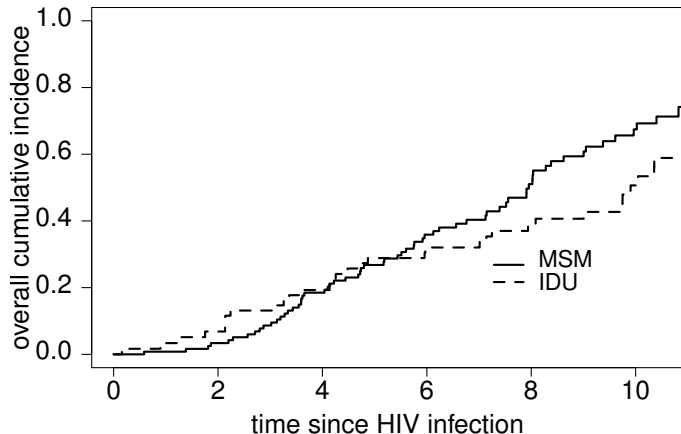
Kaplan-Meier: IDU much slower progression ($p = 0.001$)



AIDS-specific cumulative hazard

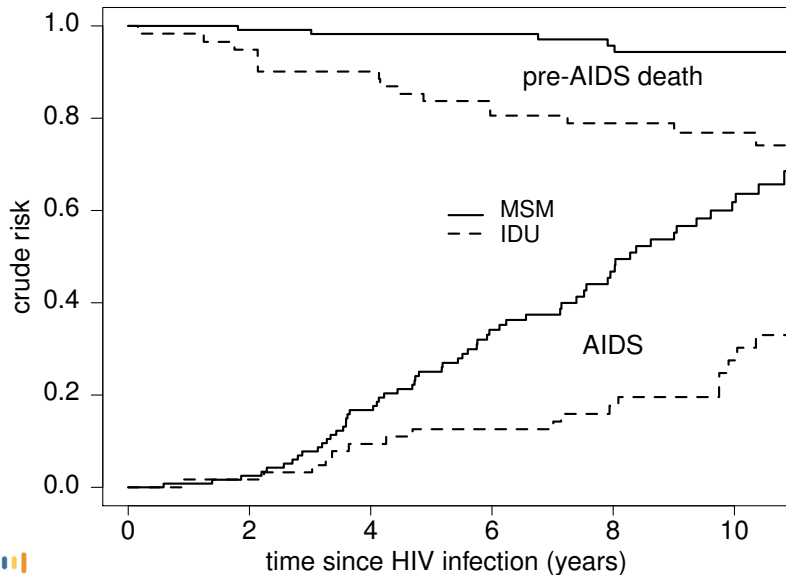


AIDS at time of death: combine AIDS and pre-AIDS death



Log-rank test: $p = 0.14$. Can we conclude that IDU and MSM have similar time to AIDS?

Never AIDS: death before AIDS treated as competing risk



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Observed data

$$\{(v_1, x_1, e_1 \delta_1), \dots, (v_N, x_N, e_N \delta_N)\}$$

Note: $t_i < c_j < v_{j'}$ in case of ties

- $x_i = \min\{t_i, c_i\}$, $\delta_i = \{t_i \leq c_i\}$, $e_i \in \{1, \dots, K\}$
- $t_{(i)}$ ordered unique event times of any type
- $d_k(t_{(i)})$ number of events at $t_{(i)}$ of type k
- $d(t_{(i)})$ total number of events at $t_{(i)}$
- $r(t_{(i)})$ number observed at risk
- $r^*(t_{(i)})$ number "in risk set" (for subdistribution hazard)

Regression: covariables $\mathbf{Z}_i = (Z_{i1}, \dots, Z_{iq})$

Basic structure Cox model

$$h(t | \mathbf{Z}_i) = h_0(t) \exp(\boldsymbol{\beta}^\top \mathbf{Z}_i)$$

$h_0(t)$ baseline hazard, same for all individuals

$$\boldsymbol{\beta}^\top \mathbf{Z}_i = \beta_1 Z_{i1} + \dots + \beta_q Z_{iq}$$

Relative hazards constant over time:

$$\frac{h(t | \mathbf{Z}_i)}{h(t | \mathbf{Z}_j)} = \frac{\exp(\boldsymbol{\beta}^\top \mathbf{Z}_i)}{\exp(\boldsymbol{\beta}^\top \mathbf{Z}_j)}$$

Estimation

Estimate of β through maximisation of partial likelihood.

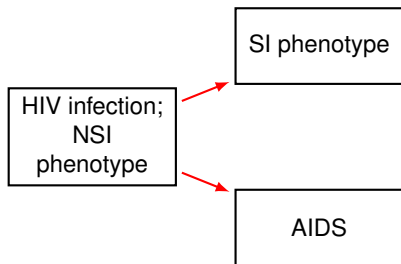
$$L(\beta) = \prod_{i=1, \delta_i=1}^N \left\{ \frac{\exp(\beta^\top \mathbf{Z}_i)}{\sum_{j=1}^N \psi_j(t_i) \exp(\beta^\top \mathbf{Z}_j)} \right\}.$$

with

$$\psi_j(t) = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if person } j \text{ not at risk at } t \\ 1 & \text{if person } j \text{ at risk at } t \end{cases}$$

- Only values at observed event times matter
- Numerator: $\mathbf{Z}_i$ from individual with event
- Denominator: all individuals in follow up at event time
- Directly extends to time-varying covariables $Z_i(t)$

C: AIDS and SI switch after HIV infection



- NSI virus needs CCR5 co-receptor for cell entry
- Gene coding for CCR5 may have deletion CCR5- Δ 32 on one chromosome
- Individuals with CCR5- Δ 32 have slower AIDS progression

- SI: "syncytium inducing phenotype". At HIV infection only NSI
- Competing risks: time to either SI switch or AIDS as first event

- Question: SI switch as first event more likely for CCR5- Δ 32 individuals?

aidsi data set, four example individuals

patnr	time	status	cause	ccr5
14	5.05	0	event-free	WW
3	2.23	1	AIDS	WW
15	10.20	1	AIDS	WM
8	8.61	2	SI	WW

Results Cox model for combined end point

```
coxph(formula = Surv(time, status != 0) ~ ccr5,  
      data = aidssi)
```

Result:

	coef	exp(coef)	se(coef)	z	p
ccr5WM	-0.701	0.496	0.186	-3.77	0.00016

Likelihood ratio test=16.5 on 1 df, p=4.95e-05 n= 324,
number of events= 220
(5 observations deleted due to missingness)

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Basic structure

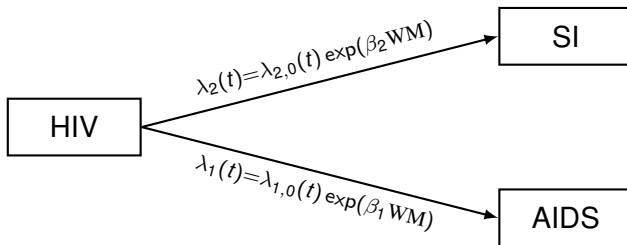
- $\lambda_k(t | \mathbf{Z}_i)$: cause-specific hazard of cause k for a subject with covariable vector $\mathbf{Z}_i$ given by

$$\lambda_k(t | \mathbf{Z}_i) = \lambda_{k,0}(t) \exp(\boldsymbol{\beta}_k^\top \mathbf{Z}_i) ,$$

with

- $\lambda_{k,0}(t)$ is the baseline cause-specific hazard for cause k
- $\boldsymbol{\beta}_k^\top = (\beta_{k1}, \dots, \beta_{kq})$ represent the covariable effects on cause k

Example: effect CCR5 Δ 32 on AIDS and SI



Basic structure

- $\lambda_k(t | \mathbf{Z}_i)$: cause-specific hazard of cause k for a subject with covariable vector $\mathbf{Z}_i$ given by

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- $\lambda_{k,0}(t)$ is the baseline cause-specific hazard for cause k
- $\beta_k^\top = (\beta_{k1}, \dots, \beta_{kq})$ represent the covariable effects on cause k
- Estimation via standard Cox model: individuals with a competing event leave the risk set

Analysis (in R)

```
coxph(Surv(time, status==1) ~ ccr5, data = aidssi)
-----
              coef exp(coef) se(coef)      z      p
ccr5WM.AIDS  -1.24      0.291    0.307  -4.02 5.7e-05

Likelihood ratio test=22  on 1 df, p=2.76e-06  n= 324,
                                number of events= 113
(5 observations deleted due to missingness)
```

Analysis (in R)

```
coxph(Surv(time, status==1) ~ ccr5, data = aidssi)
```

```
-----  
                coef exp(coef) se(coef)      z      p  
ccr5WM.AIDS  -1.24      0.291    0.307  -4.02 5.7e-05
```

```
Likelihood ratio test=22  on 1 df, p=2.76e-06  n= 324,  
                        number of events= 113  
(5 observations deleted due to missingness)
```

```
coxph(Surv(time, status==2) ~ ccr5, data = aidssi)
```

```
-----  
                coef exp(coef) se(coef)      z      p  
ccr5WM.SI  -0.254      0.776    0.238  -1.07    0.29
```

```
Likelihood ratio test=1.19  on 1 df, p=0.275  n= 324,  
                        number of events= 107  
(5 observations deleted due to missingness)
```

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Exercise II.10.1

In a study on long-term effects of treatment in childhood cancer survivors, the end point of interest was symptomatic cardiac event (CE). Comment on the following statement:

Some individuals died without CE (DOC), but they had already left the study before they died. Therefore, for CE as end point, no competing risk of DOC is present in our data and the Kaplan-Meier curve is a valid estimate of the marginal distribution of time to CE.

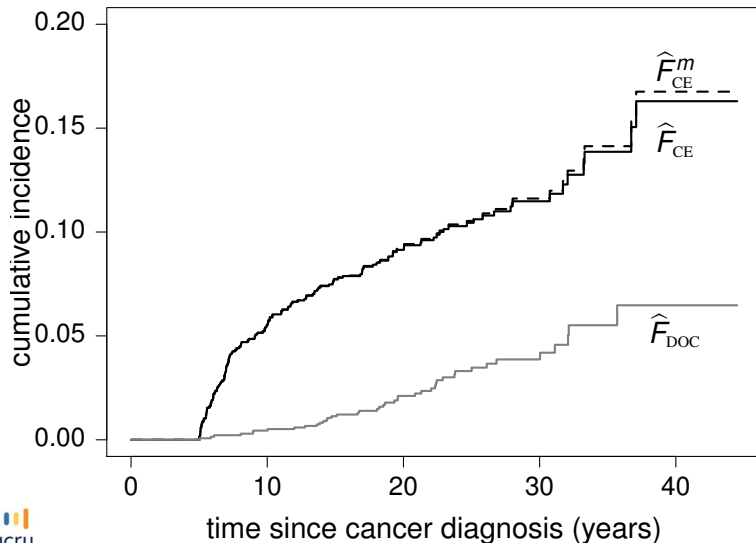
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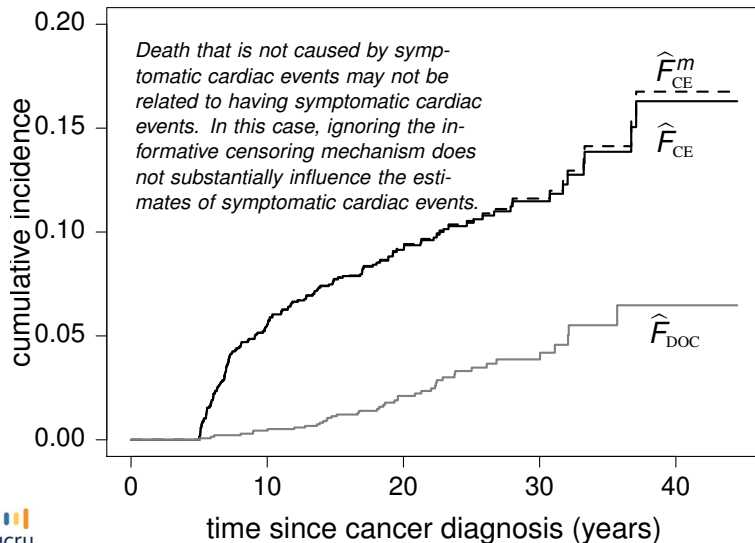
Some individuals died without CE (DOC), but they had already left the study before they died. Therefore, for CE as end point, no competing risk of DOC is present in our data and the Kaplan-Meier curve is a valid estimate of the marginal distribution of time to CE.

The Kaplan-Meier estimates the marginal distribution if all censoring is non-informative. Removing individuals from the risk set before they experience the competing event removes the competing risk, but does not solve the problem of informative censoring.

Exercise II.10.2: Childhood cancer survivors; cardiac event, DOC competing



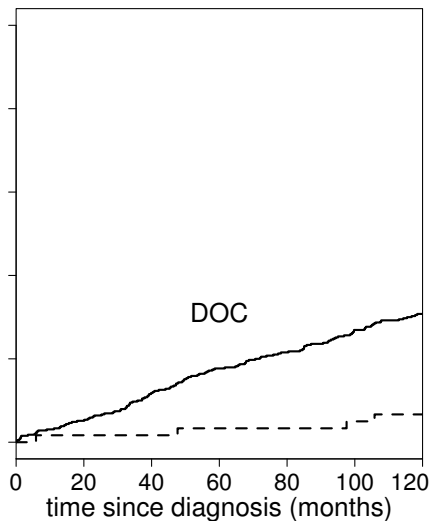
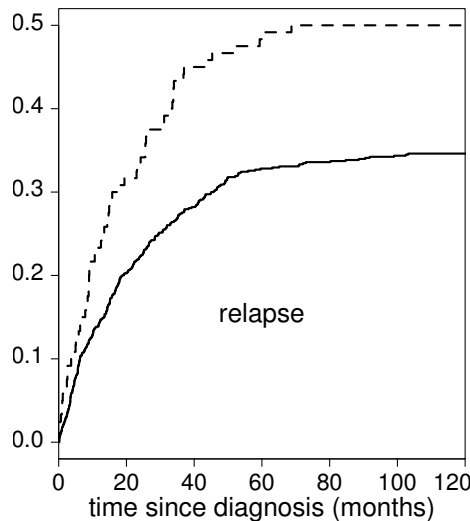
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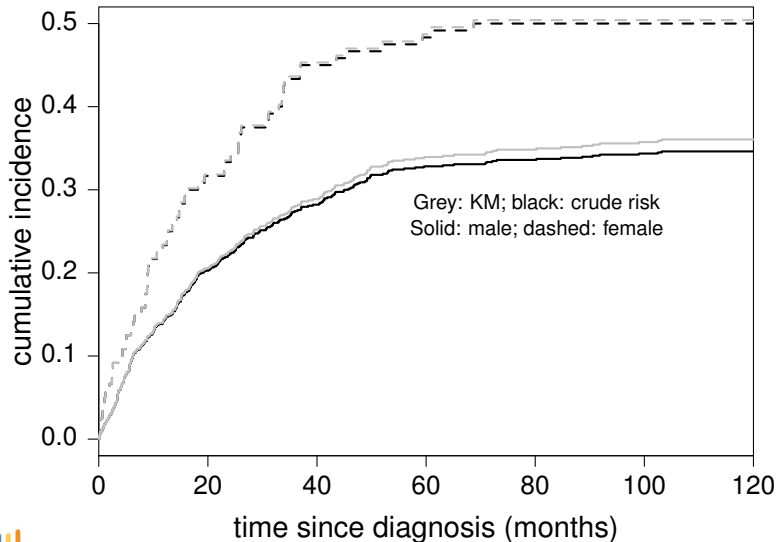
Answer

- The Kaplan-Meier and the estimator of the CE-specific cumulative incidence try to estimate different quantities
- Both curves are similar because there is little mortality due to other causes, at least during the first 20 years, when most of the CE's occur.
- Note that on one hand it is said that death due to other causes may not be related to CE events, whereas on the other hand it is called "informative censoring".

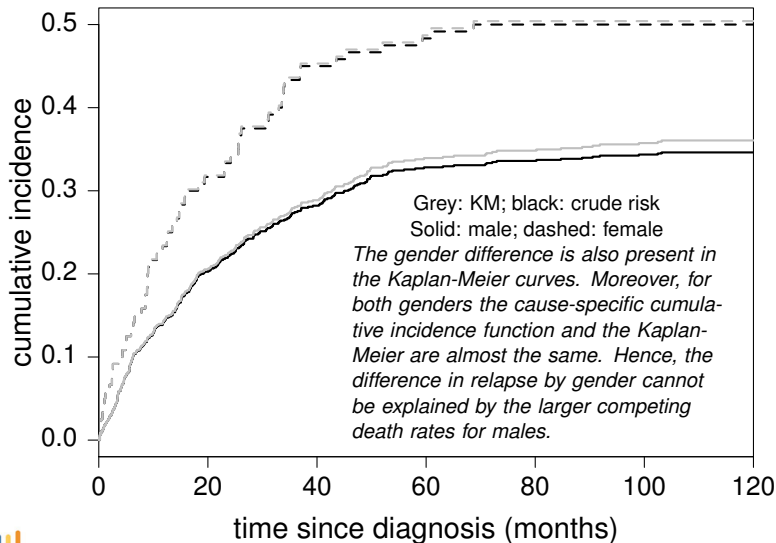
Exercise II.10.3: Bladder cancer; relapse, DOC competing



Bladder cancer; relapse, DOC competing



Bladder cancer; relapse, DOC competing



Answer

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Answer

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- Estimates almost equal because there is little mortality due to other causes, at least during the first 40 months.
- If we combine both event times, the curves for males and females will become similar. Would estimate marginal hazard if every person that died would have relapsed on the next day.
- All we can conclude is that females have a higher relapse-specific hazard than males. And females have a lower DOC-specific hazard than males.

Exercise II.10.4: Cause-specific hazard and independent censoring

In patients that receive allogeneic hematopoietic stem cell transplantation, relapse and treatment related mortality (TRM) are two competing events. Comment on the following statements:

1. The effect of a covariable on an event from either a cause-specific (e.g. relapse) model or overall (e.g. relapse and TRM combined) model may be very different from the effect of the covariable on the event (e.g. relapse) in the presence of competing risks.

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A cause-specific model quantifies the effect of a covariable on an event *in the presence of* competing risks. Statement may be correct for combined event.

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II. Using a cause-specific Cox regression model is incorrect because it ignores competing risks and treats them as censored.